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Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes

Home
Dinner guides Leftover Chicken Recipes: One Chicken, Three Dinners

Leftover Chicken Recipes: One Chicken, Three Dinners

By the Trillion Man Outreach kitchen crew Updated October 8, 2026

One chicken can quietly feed your family for three nights if you remix it. Whether you have a rotisserie bird or a batch of slow cooker chicken, these ideas keep leftovers from feeling like leftovers, with the storage rules that keep them safe.

Store it safely first

Refrigerate cooked chicken within 2 hours.

Store in airtight containers and use within 3 to 4 days.

Reheat to 165 F.

Freeze extras for later. See
freezer meals
.

The
USDA leftovers guidance
has more detail.

The three-night plan

Night 1: Chicken plate

Serve warm chicken with rice and steamed or microwaved vegetables. Shred or slice the extra and set it aside right away.

Night 2: Quesadillas or wraps

Fold shredded chicken, cheese and salsa into tortillas and crisp in a skillet 2 to 3 minutes per side.

Night 3: Quick soup

Simmer 4 cups broth with frozen vegetables for 10 minutes. Add the last of the chicken and a handful of noodles or rice and heat until hot throughout.

Five more leftover chicken ideas

Chicken fried rice.

Stir shredded chicken into
egg fried rice
.

Chicken pesto pasta.
Toss with pesto and cherry tomatoes. A great
5-ingredient dinner
.

Loaded baked potatoes.
Top with chicken, cheese and broccoli.

Chicken salad sandwiches.
Mix with mayo or Greek yogurt, celery and a little mustard.

Chicken and bean burrito bowls.
Rice, beans, chicken and salsa.

Tips for better leftover chicken

Add a splash of broth or water when reheating so it stays moist.

Add fresh flavor at the end: lime juice, herbs or hot sauce.

Keep the bones and simmer them with water, onion and carrot for homemade broth.

Shred chicken while it is still warm. It pulls apart more easily.

Cook once, eat twice

Doubling a
slow cooker chicken recipe
is the easiest way to get a head start on the next two nights. It also helps with
picky eaters
, since each night looks different even when the base is the same.

Let us take dinner off your plate

The Rescue Kit picks dinner by how tired you are. The Cheap Dinner Vault shows what each dinner costs.

Get the Rescue Kit

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Questions, answered

How long is leftover chicken good for?

Cooked chicken stored in airtight containers in the refrigerator is generally good for 3 to 4 days.

Can I freeze leftover chicken?

Yes. Cool it, store it in airtight bags or containers and use within about 3 months for best quality.

Explore every dinner guide

Keep building your weeknight plan with these related guides. Each one covers a different part of getting dinner on the table.

5-Ingredient Dinners: Short Grocery List, Real Dinner

Simple dinners with five ingredients or fewer.

Cheap Family Dinners With the Cost Per Serving

Learn to estimate cost per serving and stretch a grocery budget.

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Low-effort ideas for exhausted nights.

Easy Sheet-Pan Dinners

One-pan dinner formulas, roasting tips and easy combinations.

Freezer Meals for Busy Weeknights

Make-ahead dinner ideas, freezing tips and safe thawing guidance.

Pantry Staples List for Budget Cooking

Build a practical pantry for affordable meals and less food waste.

Picky-Eater Dinner Ideas That the Whole Table Will Eat

Low-pressure family dinner ideas and practical strategies.

Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

Hands-off slow cooker meals, timing tips and safe food handling.

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families

A seven-night dinner plan and shopping list.